
MONEYRULES SERIES

Your Credit Score

Master It, Maintain It, Leverage It

*Why it matters, how it's calculated,
and 7 proven ways to lift it in 90 days.*

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DISCLAIMER: Educational content only. Not financial advice. Reflects 2026 UK rules.

1. Introduction — Why Your Score Controls Your Life

Your credit score quietly determines a huge portion of your financial life. Mortgage rates, credit card limits, car finance, phone contracts, rental applications, even some utility deposits — all are decided by a three-digit number most people never actively manage.

The gap between a "poor" score (300-500) and an "excellent" score (800+) can easily be £50,000+ across a mortgage lifetime. Good news: the score is built from your behaviour, which means you can improve it with discipline and patience.

Your credit score is the single highest-ROI
3-digit number you'll ever track.

2. The Three UK Credit Bureaus

The UK has three major credit reference agencies. Each uses a slightly different scoring scale but pulls from similar data:

Bureau	Score Range	Free Service
Experian	0 – 999	Get a free report via MSE Credit Club
Equifax	0 – 1,000	Free via ClearScore
TransUnion	0 – 710	Free via Credit Karma

Lenders typically check one or more of these. Your scores will differ slightly across bureaus because each holds slightly different data. Never assume the one you checked is what the lender saw.

3. What Actually Moves Your Score

Factor	Weight	What It Means
Payment history	35%	On-time vs late payments in last 6 years
Credit utilisation	30%	How much of your available credit you use
Length of history	15%	How long your oldest account has been open
New applications	10%	Recent hard searches damage the score short-term
Credit mix	10%	Mix of credit cards, loans, mortgages

Payment history and utilisation alone = 65%.
Get these two right and everything else is noise.

4. 7 Proven Ways to Lift Your Score in 90 Days

1. Pay every bill by direct debit — missed payments are the #1 score killer.
2. Keep credit utilisation below 30%. Under 10% is ideal.
3. Register on the electoral roll — cheapest, fastest boost available.
4. Check your file and dispute any errors (about 20% of reports have errors).
5. Don't close old credit cards — closing shortens history and raises utilisation.
6. Avoid new applications 3 months before a big decision (mortgage/car).
7. Link your current account to credit reporting services like Experian Boost.

5. Common Credit Mistakes

- **Carrying credit cards at 80%+ utilisation — crushes your score even when paid.**
- **Applying for multiple cards in quick succession — each triggers a hard search.**
- **Closing paid-off credit cards — kills your credit history length and raises utilisation.**
- **Paying only the minimum on credit cards — costs you massive interest + keeps balance high.**
- **Ignoring old addresses on your file — can confuse identity verification.**
- **Not having ANY credit — counter-intuitive, but zero history = lenders can't assess you.**

6. Repairing a Damaged Score

A damaged score is not a life sentence. Most negative entries age off your file after 6 years. Your immediate mission is to stop the bleeding and start rebuilding:

- 8. Immediately bring all accounts current. One missed payment damages more than a dozen late ones.**
- 9. Consider a credit-builder card (Aqua, Vanquis, Capital One). High APR, low limit — use 5-15% of limit + pay in full monthly.**
- 10. Avoid applying for ANY new credit for 6 months while the score rebuilds.**
- 11. Dispute factual errors aggressively — lenders must respond within 28 days.**
- 12. Time + consistency does the rest. Expect 50-150 point recovery over 12-18 months.**

You can't buy credit repair. Anyone promising to "fix" your score for a fee is running a scam.

7. How Lenders Really Read Your Report

Scores are a summary. Lenders also look at the raw report, applying their own affordability model. They care about:

- **Stability** — same address, same employer for 2+ years is a huge positive signal.
- **Debt-to-income ratio** — total monthly debts under 40% of net income.
- **Spending patterns** — consistent outgoings vs volatile swings.
- **Gambling or short-term lending usage** — red flags in the bank statement review.
- **Employment type** — PAYE employment is weighted more favourably than self-employed.

8. Your Action Plan

- 13. Week 1: Sign up to all 3 free bureau services and download your reports.
- 14. Week 2: Register (or confirm) on the electoral roll in ALL current addresses.
- 15. Week 3: Set direct debits for every single bill and minimum credit card payment.
- 16. Week 4: Review utilisation on every card — pay down to under 30% of limit.
- 17. Month 2: Dispute any errors; wait for corrections.
- 18. Month 3: Re-check scores. Most people see a 20-60 point lift by now.

Visit www.incomeonline.info to discover 199+ platforms that can supplement your income — the surest way to improve credit utilisation is to have more income to work with.

Thank you for reading.

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